

BUILD YOUR AI CEO — THE COMPLETE SETUP GUIDE

API Key Setup Checklist

Build Your AI CEO: The Complete Setup Guide

MODULE 2 — DOWNLOAD PACKET

Your Step-by-Step Guide to Anthropic + OpenAI Keys

What is an API key?

An API key is a private password that lets your AI system connect to services like Anthropic (Claude) and OpenAI (GPT-4). Without these keys, your AI has no brain. This checklist walks you through getting both keys and setting them up correctly on your Mac.

Before You Start

Make sure you have the following ready:

- ☐ A Mac computer (these instructions are Mac-specific)
- ☐ A valid email address to create accounts
- ☐ A credit or debit card for billing setup (you won't be charged immediately)
- ☐ About 20–30 minutes to complete both setups
- ☐ Terminal app open — find it in: `Applications → Utilities → Terminal`

Part 1: Anthropic API Key Setup

Website: console.anthropic.com

Anthropic makes Claude — the AI model that powers the core intelligence in your system.

Step 1 — Create Your Anthropic Account

- ☐ Go to console.anthropic.com
 - ☐ Click "**Sign Up**"
 - ☐ Enter your email address and create a password
 - ☐ Verify your email via the confirmation link sent to your inbox
 - ☐ Complete any identity verification steps if prompted
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Step 2 — Set Up Billing

- ☐ Once logged in, click "**Billing**" in the left sidebar
- ☐ Click "**Add Payment Method**"
- ☐ Enter your credit or debit card details
- ☐ Set a **monthly spending limit** (recommended: start with \$50–\$100)
- ☐ Confirm billing setup

 **Tip:** Setting a spending limit protects you from unexpected charges during setup.

Step 3 — Generate Your API Key

- ☐ Click "**API Keys**" in the left sidebar
 - ☐ Click "**Create Key**"
 - ☐ Give your key a name — e.g., `openclaw-production`
 - ☐ Click "**Create Key**" to confirm
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Step 4 — Copy Your Key IMMEDIATELY

 **Critical:** Your API key is only shown once. If you close this page without copying it, you will have to generate a new one.

- ☐ Copy the full key (it starts with `sk-ant-...`)
 - ☐ Temporarily paste it somewhere safe — a notes app or text file
 - ☐ Do NOT share it, email it, or paste it anywhere public
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Step 5 — Add to Your Mac Environment

Open Terminal and run the following commands one at a time:

Open your shell configuration file:

▷ TERMINAL COMMAND — COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL

```
nano ~/.zshrc
```

Add this line at the bottom of the file (replace `your-key-here` with your actual key):

▷ TERMINAL COMMAND — COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL

```
export ANTHROPIC_API_KEY="your-key-here"
```

Save and exit:

- Press `Control + X`
- Press `Y` to confirm
- Press `Enter` to save

Reload your shell configuration:

▷ TERMINAL COMMAND — COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL

```
source ~/.zshrc
```

Step 6 — Verify Your Anthropic Key

Run this command in Terminal to confirm the key is loaded:

▷ TERMINAL COMMAND — COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL

```
echo $ANTHROPIC_API_KEY
```

You should see your key printed to the terminal (beginning with `sk-ant-...`). If you see nothing or a blank line, repeat Step 5.

- ☐ Key is visible when you run `echo $ANTHROPIC_API_KEY`
 - ☐ Key begins with `sk-ant-`
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Part 2: OpenAI API Key Setup

Website: platform.openai.com

OpenAI provides access to GPT-4 and image generation (DALL-E), which your AI can use for supplemental tasks.

Step 1 — Create Your OpenAI Account

- ☐ Go to platform.openai.com
 - ☐ Click **"Sign Up"**
 - ☐ Enter your email address and create a password
 - ☐ Verify your email via the confirmation link
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Step 2 — Set Up Billing

- ☐ Click your account icon (top right) → **"Billing"**
 - ☐ Click **"Add payment details"**
 - ☐ Enter your card information
 - ☐ Set a **monthly usage limit** (recommended: \$25–\$50 to start)
 - ☐ Confirm billing setup
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Step 3 — Generate Your API Key

- ☐ Click your account icon → **"API Keys"** (or go to platform.openai.com/api-keys)
 - ☐ Click **"+ Create new secret key"**
 - ☐ Give your key a name — e.g., `openclaw-main`
 - ☐ Click **"Create secret key"**
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Step 4 — Copy Your Key IMMEDIATELY

 **Critical:** Same as Anthropic — this key is only shown once.

- ☐ Copy the full key (it starts with `sk-...`)
- ☐ Temporarily paste it somewhere safe
- ☐ Do NOT share or expose it publicly

Step 5 — Add to Your Mac Environment

In Terminal, open your `.zshrc` file again:

▷ **TERMINAL COMMAND — COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL**

```
nano ~/.zshrc
```

Add this line at the bottom (replace `your-key-here` with your actual key):

▷ **TERMINAL COMMAND — COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL**

```
export OPENAI_API_KEY="your-key-here"
```

Save and exit:

- Press `Control + X` → `Y` → `Enter`

Reload:

▷ **TERMINAL COMMAND — COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL**

```
source ~/.zshrc
```

Step 6 — Verify Your OpenAI Key

▷ **TERMINAL COMMAND — COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL**

```
echo $OPENAI_API_KEY
```

You should see your key printed. If not, repeat Step 5.

- ☐ Key is visible when you run `echo $OPENAI_API_KEY`
- ☐ Key begins with `sk-`

Your Complete .zshrc Addition

After completing both setups, your `.zshrc` should have these two lines added near the bottom:

▷ **TERMINAL COMMAND – COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL**

```
# AI API Keys
export ANTHROPIC_API_KEY="sk-ant-YOUR-ACTUAL-KEY-HERE"
export OPENAI_API_KEY="sk-YOUR-ACTUAL-KEY-HERE"
```

To view your current `.zshrc` file and confirm both are present:

▷ **TERMINAL COMMAND – COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL**

```
cat ~/.zshrc
```

Billing Estimates

Understanding what you're likely to spend each month:

Anthropic (Claude)

Usage Level	Monthly Estimate
Light use (learning + occasional tasks)	\$5–\$15
Active daily use (running your AI CEO)	\$20–\$50
Heavy use (multiple agents, high volume)	\$50–\$150+

OpenAI (GPT-4 / DALL-E)

Usage Level	Monthly Estimate
Light use (supplemental tasks only)	\$2–\$5
Regular use (image gen + GPT-4 tasks)	\$5–\$20
Heavy use (large volumes)	\$20–\$50+

 **Pro Tip:** Set spending limits on both platforms. Your AI CEO is efficient, but it's wise to cap costs while you're learning.

Troubleshooting

"Command not found" when running echo

- Make sure you ran `source ~/.zshrc` after editing the file
- Try closing Terminal completely and reopening it, then run `echo $ANTHROPIC_API_KEY` again

Key shows as blank even after saving

- Open your `.zshrc` again (`nano ~/.zshrc`) and verify the line was saved correctly
- Make sure there are no extra spaces or typos in the variable name
- The format must be exactly: `export ANTHROPIC_API_KEY="your-key"`

Getting an "invalid API key" error

- Double-check that you copied the full key — they are long strings
- Make sure there are no hidden spaces at the beginning or end of the key
- Verify your billing is active on the provider's console

"Permission denied" when editing .zshrc

- This shouldn't happen with your own home directory, but if it does, try: `chmod 600 ~/.zshrc`

Key was lost before saving

- Log back into the provider console
- Deactivate the old key
- Generate a brand new key and repeat the steps

Security Reminders

These rules protect your accounts and your business. Take them seriously.

-  **Never share your API keys** with anyone — not even people you trust, unless they need access to run your systems
-  **Never commit keys to GitHub** or any public code repository — even accidentally. Use `.gitignore` to exclude `.zshrc` or any files containing keys
-  **Rotate your keys every 90 days** — log into each console and generate fresh keys on a regular schedule
-  **Store backup copies securely** — a password manager (like 1Password, Bitwarden, or Apple Keychain) is the right place

- ⚠️ **If a key is ever compromised** — go to the console immediately, revoke the exposed key, and generate a new one
 - 🛠️ **Use separate keys for testing vs. production** — if a test key gets exposed, your production system stays safe
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Final Checklist

Before moving on, confirm:

- ☐ Anthropic account created and billing active
 - ☐ Anthropic API key generated and saved to `.zshrc`
 - ☐ `echo $ANTHROPIC_API_KEY` returns your key in Terminal
 - ☐ OpenAI account created and billing active
 - ☐ OpenAI API key generated and saved to `.zshrc`
 - ☐ `echo $OPENAI_API_KEY` returns your key in Terminal
 - ☐ Both keys stored securely in a password manager
 - ☐ Monthly spending limits set on both platforms
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